

The Devil Has Your Data

The magic of a brand new Network Attached Storage (NAS) server with none of the monetary pain!

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All of us know and love the company file server. It's where we dump our essential data and programs (wink, wink), not to mention actual work-related data. It's a way of ensuring that even if our workstations decide to go south, all our hard work stays intact. It's not even an option—for every organisation with more than one person, the centralised file server has been a fixture since the early eighties.

New Wave

We're all used to file servers, but for small businesses, Network Attached Storage (NAS) is quickly emerging as a much better option. Dedicated file servers can be expensive: consider the cost of an extra license of Windows Server 2003 or another support license for Linux, not to mention the cost of the hardware to run the OS. In companies where it isn't feasible to invest in different servers for every purpose, these file servers double up as domain controllers, DNS servers or Internet gateways—much more demanding tasks. Inevitably, their performance as file servers begins to suffer, and worse, if they should crash, they'd take down more than one essential service with them.

NAS servers are cheaper—mostly because they use more basic hardware and run a rudimentary operating system that's built for the sole purpose of managing storage. They also support multiple file-sharing protocols, so Windows users can use the Common Internet File System (CIFS) protocol, and Linux users can use the Network File System (NFS) protocol, to access the same data. (Of course, this isn't really an issue if you've standardised a platform across your organisation.)

While you can get a basic NAS server for as little as Rs 8,000 (without the hard disks), the ones with more features can cost a lot more—even reaching a ridiculous Rs 35,000! And then, there's the option of turning an ageing old PC into your own NAS server...

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